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DataFest 2025: Write-Up

The 2020 pandemic had significant and prolonged effects on the global economy, including the American housing market. As companies scrambled to adapt amongst quarantine orders and uncertain supply chains, one US city saw anomalous prosperity, particularly in their technology industry. Atlanta (ATL) experienced a tech boom at the beginning of the pandemic, led by large companies like NCR and ASHREA establishing their global headquarters there in 2020. In fact, in the months of 2020 following the CDC's announcement, tech companies leased more than 3.75x more office space in ATL than they did in San Francisco (SF), USA's tradition technology hub and a city with almost double ATL's population. How and why was the ATL market able to expand and prosper while Silicon Valley and many others stagnated in the early days of the pandemic? There are multiple related factors in play, including pre-2020 rent trends; SF's rapidly increasing rent was roughly 3x more expensive than ATL's slower growing rent. After the pandemic hit, rent prices in SF fell sharply in a panic to fight the drop-off in demand (remote work, unemployment surge), and prices only started to slowly pick up pace after mid-2021, albeit still yet to reach pre-pandemic levels. In contrast, ATL's cheap rent prices were largely able to avoid any decreases and continued growing at a relatively modest rate post-pandemic. In the aftermath, SF saw its population fall by 7.4% from 2020-2023, whereas ATL's population grew by 2.4% in the same period. In more recent quarters, the proportion of office area leased in ATL and SF converged to roughly the same level, as the pandemic-triggered market correction of the prior imbalance seems to close out its effects.

External Data Citations:

U.S. Census Bureau. (n.d.). QuickFacts Atlanta city, Georgia; San Francisco County, California. https://www.census.gov/quickfacts/fact/map/US/